

need to vow that you won't make impetuous decisions and that you will pray about every decision and discuss it thoroughly.

"Andrea, you have been blessed with an ability to lead and direct. Those qualities will be very beneficial both in your career and in the home. But you must be willing to listen and let Bill be a man. God promises to guide your decisions, but you need to operate as a team and expect Bill to take responsibility.

"Now I'd like for you both to contact the bank and the credit manager for the gas company and work out a repayment plan. Tell them you're in the process of selling some assets and will pay them that money up front. Feel free to tell them you're working with me. They can e-mail me for verification. And one more thing: I'll do everything I can to help you get out of this situation, but you must agree to develop a budget together and stick to it diligently during this process. If not, I'd be better off to spend my time with those who are willing to listen."

"Okay, that all sounds doable. We'll stick to the plan. I want to get out of this mess and get our lives back on track," Bill said.

"And how about you, Andrea?" asked Mike.

"Same here," Andrea responded, "but I'm really afraid that what you said about my being an impulse spender is true. What if I can't control myself and do this again?"

"Andrea, spending is not like alcoholism or drug addiction, although it can be if you don't exercise self-control. You need to establish some guidelines for yourself that include relying on Bill to balance your extremes. Once you make a budget, don't violate it. That doesn't mean you can't ever spend any money or that you won't need some money just for your own use. Everybody does. But limit yourself to what you can afford, and don't rely on credit cards to fill in the gaps. Credit makes it too easy to splurge and is too difficult to pay back. If you stick to your repayment plan, you should be out of debt in a short while. Remember, too, that a lot of tension in marriage is from money, and you want to see your marriage start out on a good footing."